

Energy and Environment Outlook

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【メール原文】

Chile's copper output hit a 15-year low in August, threatening its role in easing global supply shortfalls. Aging mines, weather disruptions, and a fa||||||||||||

Energy and Environment Outlook
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Chile's 15-year copper production low deepens global supply crunch

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Doubts rise that Chile can resolve the world's copper supply shortfall
By Timothy Puko, Maria Luisa Puig

Chile's monthly copper production fell to a 15-year low in August, raising the risk that the copper giant may not be able to help resolve the world's long-term supply crunch. Output in the world's largest producer has dropped by one-third from its historic high at the end of 2024 to 369,500 metric tons in August, according to data from the National Statistics Institute. The International Energy Agency expects global copper supply to fall about 20% short of rising demand by 2035.

Outlook:

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Major producers have looked to Chile to help fill that gap. They have committed upward of \$20 billion in investment, and one of the largest corporate mergers in industry history depends on Chilean copper. Notably, many of those projects aim to maintain current production or expand existing operations. The latest output data show the risks of that strategy in a country with aging mines, where companies must process more rock to produce less copper.

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Severe winter weather and port disruptions have slowed operations. On 23 September, Escondida, the world's largest copper mine, also halted operations after a worker died. News reports indicate that the mine is gradually resuming activity, making its recovery a key watchpoint.

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President Jose Antonio Kast's administration offers reason for optimism after securing congressional approval for its flagship economic bill. The legislation includes measures to streamline permitting and tax changes, including a gradual cut in the corporate rate and tax stability for large investments.

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Panama may also help ease the shortfall elsewhere in Latin America. On 30 September, a ministerial committee cleared the way for the reopening of First Quantum Minerals' Cobre Panama mine. When fully operational, the mine accounts for around 2% of global supply. President Jose Raul Mulino suggested he will take time to consider next steps, likely pushing any reopening into next year (see: Mulino likely to move ahead with mine reopening despite "closure" recommendation , 30 September 2026).

German order to buy gas for storage will raise prices

By Henning Gloystein

The German government has instructed the state-controlled energy firm SEFE to buy gas. German inventories are unusually low for this time of year, at less than 60% of capacity, versus a 70% target for the start of winter on 1 November. The shortfall has raised concerns about winter shortages amid ongoing geopolitical disruptions linked to the wars in the Middle East and Ukraine. The order marks the second time since 2022 that Berlin has ordered gas purchases ahead of the peak winter demand season.

The government acted as German gas storage injections slowed after July. That pattern is unusual because the summer holiday period in July and August typically marks the peak season for injections.

Outlook:

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This year's purchase order differs from the 2022 directive, when Berlin instructed its distribution agency, Trading Hub Europe (THE), to maximize purchases for storage injections with government funds. That order drove spot gas prices to record highs after financial traders learned of the government's unconditional buying. This year, Berlin has instructed SEFE to increase purchases without specifying timing or volumes.

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Still, Berlin's order will likely raise spot gas prices because SEFE must buy gas soon to ensure delivery and injection before winter begins on 1 November in the gas industry calendar. The purchases will move Germany closer to its storage targets and will probably be enough to secure winter supplies (see: European gas prices will stay elevated through winter , 22 September 2026)

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SEFE could increase imports of Russian LNG before the end of the year. The company holds a long-term contract with Russia's Novatek for 2.9 million tons a year that expires in 2027 under the EU's plan to phase out Russian gas. SEFE has sought to replace the Russian LNG with supplies under contracts with ADNOC Gas in the UAE and Angola LNG. It remains unclear whether ADNOC can fully deliver those volumes given the situation in the Middle East (see: High oil prices likely throughout 2026 as US-Iran standoff endures , 18 September 2026)

Permitting package likely to pass with new conditions for data center power consumption

By Timothy Puko, Herbert Crowther

On 30 September, a bipartisan group of US senators released the text of a potential permitting reform package. If enacted, the package would significantly improve the outlook for US energy investments in generation and transmission. For data centers in particular, the package would allow more power supply to come online, but at a higher cost (see: Permitting package would accelerate timelines and raise costs

for data center power procurement , 1 October 2026)

Outlook:

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The release of the final bill text this week sets up a vote in Congress's lame-duck session after the midterms.

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The House poses the main threat to the legislation. A key House Democrat has already said the caucus may prefer to wait until the next session if the midterms strengthen their position. The same dynamic has derailed recent permitting overhaul efforts. Democrats may also doubt that the White House will honor its commitments to reduce delays it has imposed on dozens of wind and solar projects.

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For data centers, this package would improve access to power but raise costs. Data centers would have to pay for any interregional transmission built for them, and utilities could not spread the costs of data center-related investments across the broader consumer rate-paying base. States and utilities have already moved in this direction by creating large-load tariffs for data centers, and the package would reinforce that trend. The package sets the minimum threshold for data center power consumption at 20 megawatts (MW), which would cover the vast majority of new US data centers.

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The package creates new remedies for onshore and offshore wind projects stalled by federal approval delays over the last 12 months, but will do little to revive interest in new US offshore wind projects.

UK state-owned grid firm aims to accelerate network expansion

By Henning Gloystein

British Prime Minister Andy Burnham has announced plans for GB Grid, a state-owned company. The entity will sit within GB Energy, a state-owned investment firm founded by Burnham's predecessor, Prime Minister Keir Starmer. GB Grid will work with private-sector energy, network, and industrial firms to accelerate power connections.

Outlook:

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Although the plan still lacks detail, GB Grid's main task will be to accelerate the UK's power grid expansion so it can keep pace with rising generation capacity. The effort is necessary to help lower UK power prices, which are among the highest in Europe.

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GB Grid will likely partner with private network investors to speed up grid expansion and meet growing demand. The company could also compete directly in tenders. If partnerships with GB Grid speed up the UK's slow grid access process, they will likely help reduce power costs by 2030.

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GB Grid will receive about £4 billion in funding during this parliamentary term, through 2029. The funding will come from GB Energy's £8.3 billion (\$11 billion) budget for the same period. The government has already allocated the remainder to UK nuclear power development and support for small-scale local power projects.

DOE likely to take targeted approach to bulk power system executive order

By Herbert Crowther

President Donald Trump's administration's late-August executive order on the bulk power system gives the Department of Energy (DOE) broad authority to classify specific energy technologies as cyber risks to the US grid and to mandate mitigation measures, including the removal and replacement of those assets (see: New executive order raises risks for Chinese tech in US grid , 3 September 2026). The executive order formally covers a wide range of energy technologies, including finished battery energy storage system (BESS) units.

Outlook:

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DOE officials are evaluating how to implement the executive order by mid-December. The department is now focused on that deadline, when it must determine which technologies it will classify as high risk under the new rules. Because the mandate is new, DOE will need to coordinate closely with other agencies.

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Despite the wide scope of the order, DOE will likely focus on the technologies that are most exposed to cyber risk, such as inverters. DOE is unlikely to target technologies that pose more limited cyber risks and play a larger role in meeting near-term load growth, such as BESS. The administration is also unlikely to use the bulk power system executive order as a broader tool to restrict renewable energy projects.

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Combined with the Federal Communications Commission's (FCC) July actions, the executive order makes China-linked inverters the grid technology most likely to face additional US policy targeting existing assets, including under the bulk power system executive order.

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Continued tightening of the US policy environment toward Chinese hardware was not a focus during President Xi Jinping's visit to Washington last week. Discussions about Chinese-linked cleantech manufacturing investments in the US under the Board of Investment are unlikely to progress in the coming months, and the bulk power executive order would significantly raise the domestic policy risks for any such projects (see: Summit lowers odds of year-end bilateral breakdown , 25 September 2026).

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